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Popular Literature 060

12 December 2025

Queering the Canon: Exploring the Phenomenon of Queer Shipping in the Marvel Cinematic
Universe Fandom

Since I can remember, the Marvel Cinematic Universe, or the MCU, has provided me with a great sense of comfort and entertainment. Watching this decades-spanning set of movies and television shows not only provided me with hours of enjoyment but also made me feel larger than life, just like the superheroes. Since the MCU was my biggest obsession and source of solace, I began engaging with fandom content on various social media platforms. While I had not ventured over to Archive of Our Own and other fan fiction sites at this point, I was aware of the shipping culture in the fandom, as well as what ships were popular. It was at this point that I started to notice a certain trend within the MCU fandom. Despite all of the male characters canonically being in heterosexual romantic relationships with their female counterparts across all MCU movies and TV shows, some of the most popular ships in the fandom are male-loving-male romantic relationships. The most infamous example of this phenomenon includes the romantic shipping of the two male MCU characters, Tony Stark and Steve Rogers. Despite the two characters having standalone movies where their heterosexual romantic relationships were at the forefront of the movies' plots, fans insist on pairing Tony and Steve together romantically.

After noticing this trend, I wanted to conduct my own investigation and research to see whether or not this queer phenomenon was actually taking place, or if it was simply a trend consistently showing up on my “For You Page.” Furthermore, I wanted to know if there was a motivation or central cause behind the rise of MLM shipping in the MCU Fandom, and the overall messages that audiences can take away from these findings. Since the rise of the MCU, there has been a “queering the canon” phenomenon taking place within the fandom, as visualized through various Gephi and Tableau datasets, and the reasoning behind this growing trend is due to a lack of well-written female characters and the lack of queer characters across all MCU media.

In order to conduct my research, I first had to identify my methodology and how I wanted to measure the information I wanted to represent. I knew I wanted to visualize my data in a way that highlighted the connections between two male characters across AO3. Because of this, I decided to use software programs like Gephi and Tableau to collect all of my data. These programs not only visualize data in a way that is easy to analyze, but they also produce illustrations that easily demonstrate connection and intersectionality, perfectly demonstrating instances of male characters romantically overlapping in fan fictions.

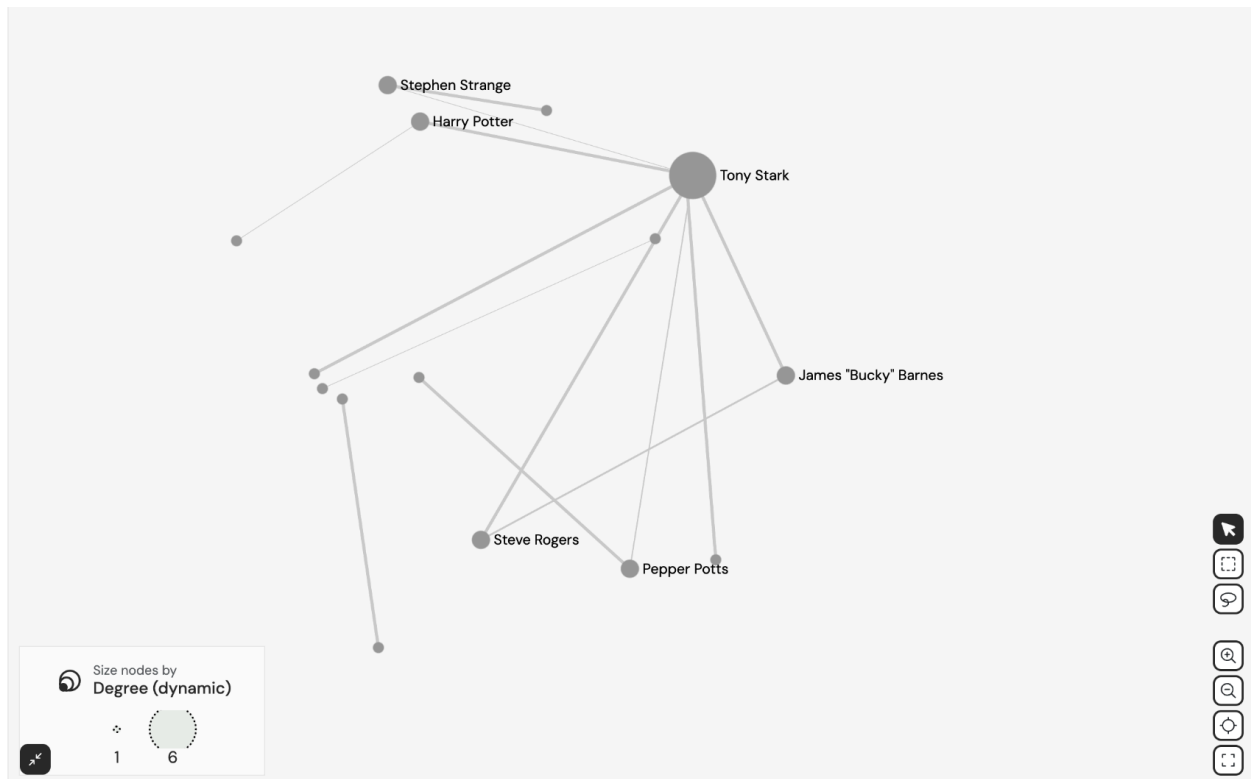
Before importing my data, I had to identify my dataset. On AO3, there are currently 529,359 works created under the Marvel Cinematic Universe tag, which is the tag containing fan fiction about the series of movies and television shows produced specifically under Marvel Studios. For my personal data collection, I decided to pull works from the Marvel Cinematic Universe tag with the most kudos. When a fan fiction receives a kudos on AO3, this is the reader's way of awarding the quality of the work to its author, and oftentimes, the more kudos a

fan fiction has, the more “popular” or highly regarded the work is within the fandom. Because of this, I wanted to pull my data from the top 2,000 Marvel Cinematic Universe fan fictions with the most kudos. By utilizing the data from what is considered the most popular work within the MCU fandom, I can properly discover if the phenomenon of MLM romantic shipping is as popular within the fandom as I hypothesized. I also decided to pull the top 2,000 works because I believed this number was vast enough to properly demonstrate this phenomenon.

After pulling the tags from the top 2,000 MCU works, I decided to isolate each character that had a “slash” (/) in their tag. On AO3, if two characters had a slash in their tag, this meant the fan fiction contained a romantic storyline between these characters. For my research, it was essential that I isolate any slash tags from any tags with an “and” (&), because ands typically symbolize a platonic relationship between two characters. Since I only intend to measure the romantic relationships across these top 2,000 works, any information about platonic relationships is irrelevant to my research. While going through my dataset, I also kept any crossover ships that were pulled from the top 2,000 works. This means that characters from other fandoms were included in my dataset for my research, particularly characters from the *Harry Potter* universe. However, I was fine with this because, despite these characters being from different fandoms, I can still use them to identify heterosexual versus MLM romantic shipping. After thoroughly combing through my dataset, I was able to upload the data to my software programs to have them generate the visuals necessary for my research.

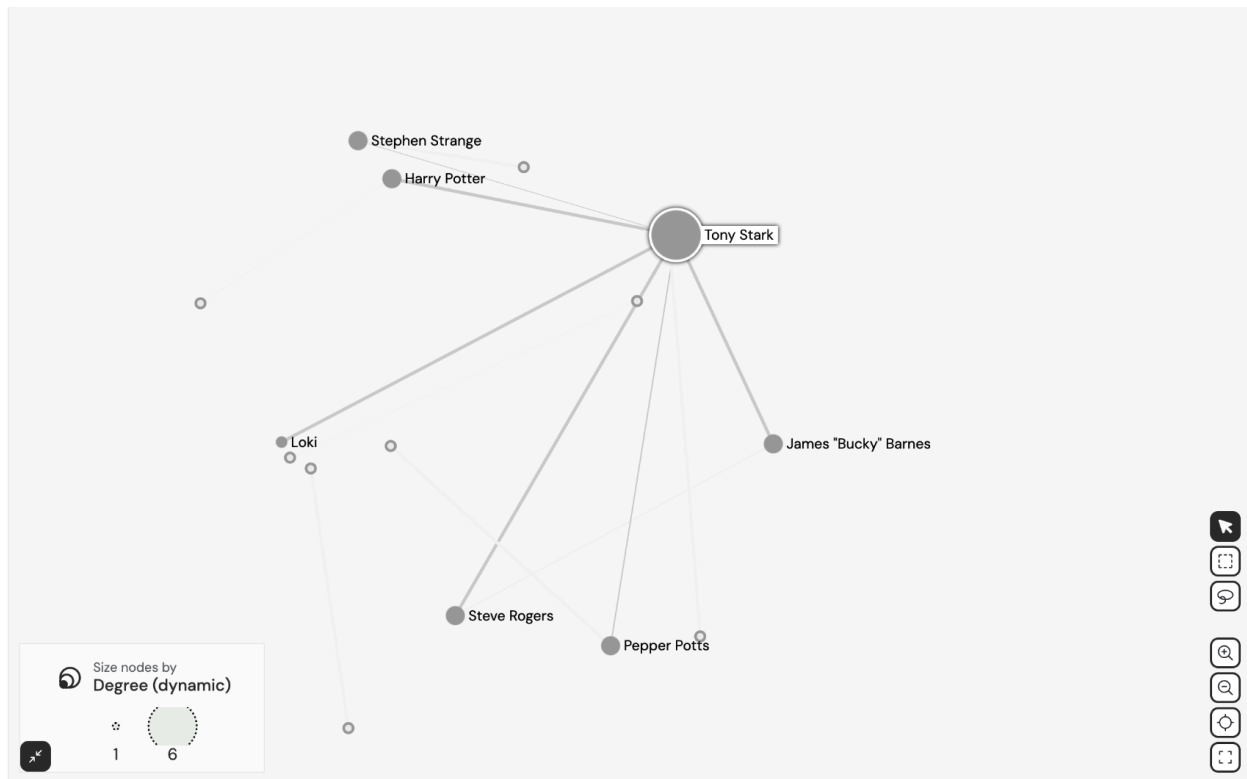
The methodology I utilized first when conducting my research was using Gephi to demonstrate the most popular romantic relationships across Archive of Our Own. After uploading my dataset into the software, I decided to change some of the visual settings. I chose

to change the node sizes to reflect the number of times the character was mentioned across all 2,000 works. Doing this helped me better portray how popular certain characters are within the works I had pulled from. After making these changes, I was able to produce this visual to represent my data.



Right away, one can notice that Tony Stark is the most mentioned character across these top 2,000 works. This makes sense because he is considered the main character across all MCU movies and television shows. Taking this into account, I made Tony the focal point of my research. Since he is the most popular character across the top 2,000 MCU works, it makes sense to study the romantic pairings he is placed in. Within the MCU canon, Tony Stark is in a heterosexual romantic relationship with Pepper Potts, where they eventually get married and

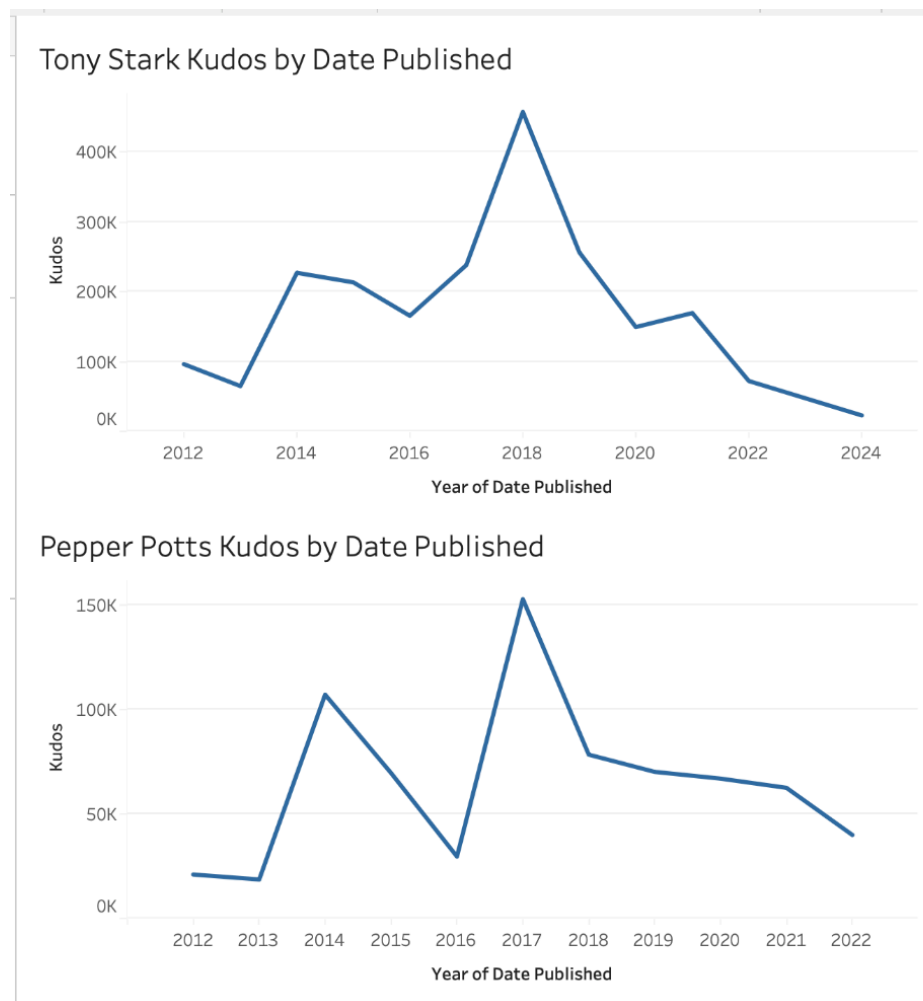
have a daughter together. However, when I highlight all the nodes that are connected to Tony Stark, this is where my theory starts to come to life.



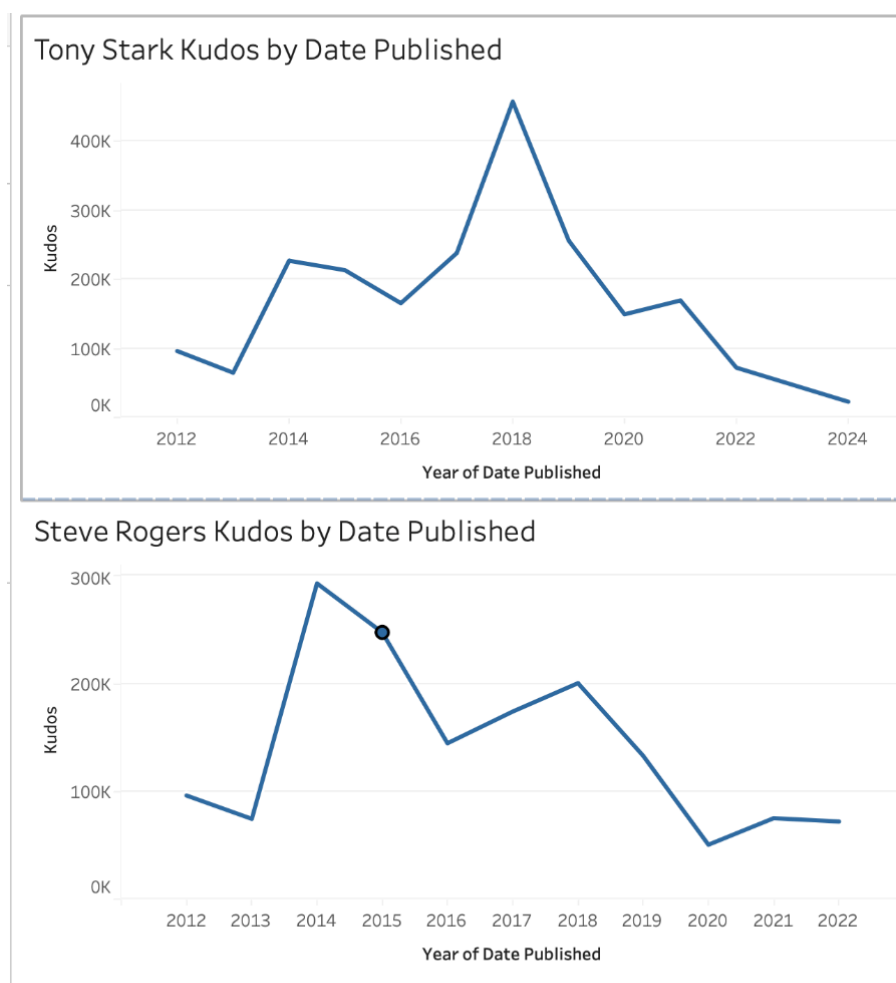
Despite Tony being romantically paired with Pepper in the MCU canon, this visual shows that in other instances across the top 2,000 MCU works on AO3, he is shipped romantically with other male characters. In fact, Tony and Pepper are the only popular heterosexual romantic pairing in this visualization, as Tony is only shipped romantically with other male characters across these works. This means that works that center around the MLM romantic ship dominate the works focused on the canonical straight ship within the MCU fandom.

The second methodology I wanted to utilize for my research is Tableau to compare some individual character metrics across AO3. After I uploaded my dataset into the software, I decided to customize my own graphs. I formulated my graphs to show the total amount of kudos each

work received based on the character features since the MCU fandom works started being uploaded in 2012. I would then adjust the filter to change the character whose data I was observing to see if there were any correlations. Once again, I decided to use Tony Stark as my basis or character whose data I was comparing with other data. Because Tony is the most popular male character, I decided to study his data in comparison to that of other frequently featured male characters. Once again, I started by comparing the number of kudos works featuring Tony Stark received as opposed to the number of kudos works featuring Pepper Potts received. This comparison gave me the following visual.



As portrayed, despite Tony Stark receiving over 400,000 kudos at the character's most popular point in time, Pepper Potts received less than half of those kudos at her most popular point in time. This data demonstrates that Pepper is not predominantly featured across the MCU fandom's most popular romantic works, despite her canonical romantic relationship with Tony. I then decided to compare Tony's data with other popular male character's data, that being Steve Rogers. As I noted earlier, Tony Stark and Steve Rogers were one of the prevailing MLM romantic ships I had seen across the MCU fandom, and I wanted to see if there was data to back up this trend. After filtering in Steve Rogers' data and comparing it to Tony Stark's data, this is the visual I had produced.



In Steve Rogers' graph, the character received a little under 300,000 kudos at his most popular point in time. However, when comparing the number of times when Tony Stark and Steve Rogers were both mentioned in a work with a large number of kudos, the numbers are very similar. This means that across the most popular fan fiction works on AO3, there are more romantic stories featuring Tony and Steve than there are romantic stories featuring Tony and Pepper. This once again visualizes the trend of works featuring MLM romantic shipping being some of the most popular within the MCU fandom. Despite Pepper Potts being Tony's canonical love interest, members of the MCU fandom insist on romantically shipping him with male characters such as Steve Rogers in some of the fandom's most popular works on AO3.

Through my usage of software programs such as Gephi and Tableau, I have been able to support my theory that MLM romantic shipping dominates the MCU fandom. This trend is not surprising though, as exploring relationship dynamics, specifically romantic MLM dynamics, is very common within fan spaces. In Vadde and So's article "Fandom and Fictionality after the Social Web: A Computational Study of AO3," the authors argue that web-based fanfiction, especially on AO3, has become an important and understudied form of modern fiction that reveals how contemporary readers transform, reinterpret, and socially interact around popular texts. Vadde and So write, "Shipping in fanfic realizes in written form the redistributions of character attention that serve as reinterpretations and ultimately personalizations of source fiction." The authors also go on to note that creating or reading queer fan fiction works can create a feminist or queer representation of romance that may not have been depicted in the fandom previously, writing, "Slash has historically broken taboos around same-sex love while promoting a feminist version of romance premised on the alliance of equals." While Vadde and

So's research has been insightful, I wanted to conduct more research as to why queer shipping is so popular within the MCU fandom specifically, and if this lack of feminist or queer representation might be part of the reasoning behind it.

Since the start of the MCU, one of the biggest points of controversy has been the treatment of the series's female characters. In an article written for The Purbalite, author Katelynn Burger summarizes the primary complaints with MCU female characters: "Marvel is incapable of writing compelling female characters, and it's detrimental to their movies' storylines. Marvel's female characters all have one or more of these faults: They are defined by their male love interest; their character growth is completely off-screen; they are a plot device; they are ingrained with toxic femininity; or they become a female version of their male counterpart. That's not even to mention just how over sexualized they are."

One of the best examples of this phenomenon described by Burger is the dynamic between the characters Steve Rogers, Bucky Barnes, and Peggy Carter. Over the course of the MCU movie franchise, the canon plot establishes that Steve and Peggy are in love and attempt to pursue a romantic relationship. However, Peggy Carter's character is extremely underwritten. As an audience, we do not learn much about her besides the fact that she works for the US Army during WWII, and she is romantically involved with Steve. Her character ultimately serves no goal other than developing the character arc and storyline of her male counterpart. Now, let's compare Peggy's character to Bucky's character. Despite starting out simply as Steve Rogers' best friend, he eventually evolves into a highly complex character. Over the course of the MCU movies, Bucky becomes a prisoner of war and ends up being brainwashed into becoming a mindless spy for Hydra called the Winter Soldier. Right off the bat, Bucky's character is a lot

more complex than Peggy's because his character serves a purpose outside of developing the story and character of Steve. This leaves audiences with two developed male characters and one underdeveloped female character. Because Peggy is an underwritten character, audiences are not as connected to her as they are to Steve and Bucky. This results in audiences and members of the MCU fandom being more motivated to imagine stories only including Steve and Bucky because they are more interesting characters. Moreover, this then results in audiences and members of the fandom imagining what a romantic relationship between Steve and Bucky might look like as opposed to Steven and Peggy.

Now apply this issue of underwritten female characters to almost every movie within the MCU, and this results in a multitude of “queering the canon” fan fiction stories. In an article by Medium, author Sophia Insua actually provides statistics about female representation across the MCU: “Between every single film that Marvel released from 2008–2018, male heroes took up over 29 hours of screen time while their female counterparts received a mere 4 hours. Furthermore, only 56% of Marvel films manage to pass the Bechdel test. Finally, out of over 7,000 characters in the entire Marvel universe, just 31% are female. Nearly 65 years have passed since Marvel published its first comic, yet the company has failed to alter its hero demographics in any significant way.”

Another issue within the MCU fandom that perpetuates this queering of the canon trend is the lack of queer representation within the MCU to begin with. Since the MCU started, queer characters have rarely appeared onscreen. Even if the comic book character that the studio planned to adapt was queer, executives would oftentimes intervene and change these traits and storylines. The most notable instance of this was in the film *Thor: Ragnarok* with the character

Valkyrie. Despite Valkyrie being bisexual in the Marvel comics, the actress portraying Valkyrie being bisexual herself, and director Taika Waititi approving the queer storyline, fans were surprised when the film had no mention of the character's queerness. In an OSA Telegraph article, the author goes into detail about the alleged studio interference, writing "Tessa Thompson, who portrays Valkyrie in the film, pitched her character's bisexuality to director Taika Waititi, citing the 2013 Fearless Defenders comics, in which Valkyrie is confirmed to be bisexual and shares a kiss with Annabelle Riggs. Waititi liked the idea, and they shot a few scenes in *Ragnarok* that alluded to her potential queerness –but ultimately they were all cut from the film. What remains is a brief flashback of Valkyrie and her Asgardian sisters being slain in battle, when another woman warrior sacrifices her life to save Valkyrie's. The scene isn't romantic, not unless you really read into it. Queer audiences, who are known to be quite perceptive, didn't even make the connection that this woman might be her lover until information about the deleted scenes was revealed."

Although there have been more recent attempts with MCU writers utilizing queer characters within their stories, rarely are these relationship dynamics ever explored on screen. The best example of this is the character of Loki. In the first season of the *Loki* television series, the character was confirmed to be genderfluid through the visual of a "wanted" document that had "Gender: Fluid" written on it. Loki's sexuality is also confirmed in this series in an interaction with an alternate universe female version of himself, Sylvie. In this interaction, Sylvie asks if Loki has had any romantic rendezvous with princesses or princes, and Loki confirms his bisexuality by saying, "a bit of both." While this was a huge moment for queer representation in the MCU, these mentions are very quick and easy to miss if you are not searching for them. This

subtlety was even more odd when one takes into account that Loki is also genderfluid and bisexual in the Marvel comics. Author Elizabeth A. Jankowski makes note of this in a journal article for the *Journal of Feminist Scholarship*, writing, “Multiple characters that are queer in the comics have had their identities erased in the movies to make them more palatable to the mainstream conservative audience. Loki is a character that is both bisexual and genderfluid in the comics (Loki Laufeyson (Earth – TRN747), 2021). His queer identity was briefly mentioned in the Loki (2021) Disney+ series in two ‘blink and you will miss it’ moments.” However, despite all these attempts to include queer diversity in the MCU through Loki and the *Loki* series, the character still ends up in a heterosexual romantic relationship with Sylvie. While this decision was justified by the writers, as ending up with a female version of himself is a representation of Loki’s own narcissism, this resulted in pushback from the MCU fandom, not only for once again sacrificing onscreen queer relationship dynamics, but also for discussing the ethics of “self-cest.”

Despite the MCU predominantly featuring heterosexual relationship dynamics across all of its movies and television series, MLM romantic shipping is one of the most prevalent trends across all of the most popular MCU works on AO3. Using visuals from Gephi allowed me to demonstrate how the MCU’s main character, Tony Stark, is more often romantically shipped with men than he is women. Moreover, the graphics produced by Tableau allowed me to demonstrate a higher correlation of works featuring a romance between Tony Stark and Steve Rogers than works featuring the MCU’s canon relationship of Tony Stark and Pepper Potts. I also was able to identify the root of this trend, that being the lack of well-written female characters in the MCU, as opposed to their properly developed male counterparts, and the overall

lack of queer representation in the MCU to begin with. While there is nothing wrong with creating work centered around non-canonical queer relationships, the intention behind this phenomenon comes from a lack of diversity and poor writing in the MCU that I wanted to highlight within my research and writing. I hope that my work will motivate others to think more critically about the superhero movies you consume and speak out about the lack of diversity within some of the biggest movies of our generation.

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